

Medical Emoji

A one-page brief for the American Medical Informatics Association

Prepared for the AMIA Board

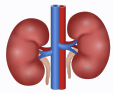
medicalemoji.org

Shuhan He, MD · June 2026

THE ASK — ONE THING

A single **AMIA letter of support to the Unicode Consortium**, modeled on the one ACEP wrote, affirming the value of a standardized set of medical emoji. It commits AMIA to nothing else — we handle the Unicode proposals, the usage evidence, and the artwork. **A turnkey draft letter is attached.**

The 6 symbols in our **August 2026** Unicode submission



Kidney

Chronic kidney disease
~10% of adults



Liver

~2M deaths/yr; NAFLD
~25% of US adults



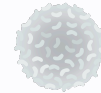
Stomach

GI disease, GERD, ulcers



Spine

Low back pain: #1 cause
of disability



White blood cell

Infection, immunity,
sepsis



EKG

Cardiovascular disease,
#1 killer

We have done this before



In 2020 our physician team added the first anatomically accurate **heart** and **lungs** to the Unicode Standard. They now render on **essentially every phone** — Apple (iOS 14.2), Google, Samsung, Microsoft. This is the proven next slate, not a concept pitch.

The evidence is published

- **JAMA** (2021) — the clinical case for medical emoji.
- **JAMA** (2022) — an emoji pain scale matched the standard numeric scale.
- **JAMA Network Open** (2023) — the case for a comprehensive set.
- Covered by the **Boston Globe & The Verge**; **STAT** (Jan 2026) found emoji rising fast in clinical records.

Organized medicine already backs it

ACEP — whole project AGA ASGE ASN ISN
NKF KDIGO AAKP + a dozen more

What is still missing is the voice of **organized informatics**. That is AMIA.

Why this is AMIA's lane

Medical emoji are **standardized clinical iconography** — a controlled-vocabulary, interoperability, and patient-communication problem. Unicode rewards two things: real-world usage (we build that) and a recognized authority affirming a symbol matters and is well-defined. The national informatics body is the ideal source of the second.

July 17

World Emoji Day — the moment to publish letters of support

July 31

Unicode's intake deadline for this cycle

August 1

Our target to have all letters in hand

Shuhan He, MD · Massachusetts General Hospital · Founder, The Medical Emoji Project · medicalemoji.org · @ShuhanHeMD | A letter by **mid-July** is ideal — no pressure, and we move at AMIA's pace.